Hello Herman

By John Buffalo Mailer

HERMAN: **(Pg 40)** *(meanacing, he struts around with a gun – this is the happiest moment of his life)* Paul! Paul Schruber! Today is your lucky day! Because you are so valuable to our school, you get to live! Now, take a bow and get out of my gym, Paul. *(Paul moves toward the exit)* You forgot to take a bow! *(Herman shoots him in the knee – Paul falls down, screaming in pain)* Shut up!

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CLARKSON: **(Pg 12)** Forty-three students were shot before [Herman]Howards was apprehended. "Bloody Broome" as it is now being called, is the worst high-school massacre in the history of America. **(Pg 15)** While there remains no clear motive for the killings, what has become very clear, is that today's teenage culture is rampant with violence . . . Senator John Cox issued a statement to the press this morning.

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SENATOR JOHN COX: *(Overlap lines with Children's Aid Society Rep)* Herman Howards is not a common criminal; he is a terrorist, pure and simple. A coward. He must be executed. And his execution ought to be televised nationally, so that America's children can witness what happens when you disregard the value of life.

CHILDREN'S AID SOCIETY REP: Herman Howards is a troubled child in serious need of psychiatric treatment. What kind of message does it send to the world when America starts executing our own children on television? Killing people does not stop people from killing people.

INTRODUCTION

1999 - Columbine, Colorado. 15 people dead. 2012 - Sandy Hook Elementary, CT. 28 people dead. 2018 - Parkland, Florida. 17 people dead. And while the COVID-19 pandemic appears to have interrupted the trend line, it does not mean schools are "safer."

It's hard to empathize with someone who carries out a school shooting. The brutality of their crime is unspeakable. Whether the shootings were at Columbine, Sandy Hook or Parkland, they have traumatized students and communities across the US. But understanding the culture and the

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mentality of school shooters are the keys to prevention. Unfortunately, our society seems to be focused on punishment rather than prevention. Are consequences and active shooter drills the answer? Or are we asking all the wrong questions?

Hello Herman by John Buffalo Mailer

LAX: **(Pg 11)** This Week's Topic: High School Terrorists . . **(Pg 18)** *(a buzzer goes off. We hear the sound of a prison door opening. Herman enters)* **(Pg 25)** *(To Herman)* Hello, Herman

HERMAN: "Hello, Herman!" Starring Herman Howards and Lax Morales. I get top billing? I mean, it is my story.

LAX: Get it straight, Herman. I'm not here to turn you into a rock star. I'm here because there's a world outside that thinks you should be electrocuted, at age sixteen, on national television. That's a story. That's important.

HERMAN: **(Pg 19)** *(explodes)* I'm an individual! Don't forget that! You think just anyone could do what I did? No sir. There's only one Herman Howards, and now history will remember me.

LAX: You don't talk like the average sixteen-year-old kid.

HERMAN: I'm not your average sixteen-year-old. I'm America's worst nightmare.

CLARKSON: **(Pg 30)** We'll be right back.

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CLARKSON: **(Pg 12)** *(Overlap lines with Clarkson (2))* While parents of the formerly peaceful community of Broome, Iowa grieve the tragic loss of their children. Parents all over suburban America are wondering if their town will be next.

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LAX: **(Pg 18-19)** May I interview you now? *(long beat)*

HERMAN: How much money do I get for talking to you?

LAX: You don't get anything. Any money goes to the families of the victims. Besides. I thought you wanted to tell your story. *(beat)* Did you get picked on a lot at school, Herman?

HERMAN: *(shrugs it off)* The jocks call me names cause I'm small. They'd push me around.

LAX: You kids still play Doom . . . Postal?

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HERMAN: **(Pg 20)** I own it *(he begins to ramp up)* You're a postal worker. You go into the office one day cause you've had enough of people's crap and you shoot everyone up til they're all gone. *(Herman laughs)*

LAX: Your mom supports you in playing games like Postal?

HERMAN: I don't think she knows anything about it. **(Pg 28)** We don't interfere with each other. She's very good about giving me my privacy.

LAX: What about your father? *(long beat)*

HERMAN: **(Pg 35)** He left when I was eight.

LAX: **(Pg 28)** When you were eleven, your sister was hurt in a hit-and-run, right? She died a few days later.

HERMAN: Yeah.

LAX: It happened right outside your house . . . did you go out and help her.

HERMAN: I was eleven. There wasn't a whole hell of a lot I could have done, now was there. **(Pg 29)** You really don't get it!

LAX: Don't get what?

HERMAN: **(Pg 27)** *Jesus Christ* you're asking stupid questions. I thought you were supposed to be some kind of hotshot reporter. **(Pg 29)** I'm done talking to you today. *(long beat)*

LAX: **(Pg 27)** Okay, let's cut to it. **(Pg 40)** Tell me more about the day you did it. You rounded up all the kids in the gym. . .

HERMAN: **(Pg 20-21)** Yeah *(Herman smiles)* You had to be there. At one point this girl started running for the door. *(gunshot)* I clipped her right in the back of the head and her face exploded and landed all over some kid *(breaks into laughter)* Thought she was home free . . . when all of a sudden, "OOPS! THERE GOES MY FACE!"

LAX: Do you even know the girl's name?

HERMAN: She was background. Not a key player.

LAX: It was a game, wasn't it?

HERMAN: It's all a game, Lax. **(Pg 37)** If I could just get one more game in, I'd be happy.

LAX: **(Pg 26)** You feel no remorse?

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HERMAN: *(pause)* I didn't want to kill Mr. Phelps.

*****flashback******

(Mr. Phelps enters and slowly walks toward Herman)

MR. PHELPS: **(Pg 40)** There's still time. Stop this madness, Herman.

HERMAN: Sit down! I don't want to kill you! *(Phelps keeps walking toward Herman, his hand out asking for the gun. Gunshot. Phelps falls) (to Lax)* I had to shoot. He would have grabbed me if I didn't. He looked so stupid. I almost started laughing, but out of respect, I didn't. *(Pause – flashback continues)* Are there any other teachers in the room? *(to Lax)* I knew Ms. Cribb was there. No one came forward, so I called up three kids who were lying on the floor near me. Susan, this bitchy girl no one really liked, James, the editor of the school paper and Marsha, the hottest girl in school. *(flashback continues)* **(Pg 42-43)** Hello! If you are a teacher, please come forward and take a bow! *(no response – he puts the gun to Susan's head)* Oink!

SUSAN: What?

HERMAN: Oink! Like in Deliverance. Squeal! *(She tries, but is crying too much)*

SUSAN: Jesus, please protect me. Jesus, please protect me . . . .

HERMAN: *(gets a kooky expression on his face, then starts to laugh)* Not today. *(Gunshot- end flashback) (To Lax)* I shot her at an angle, so the bullet would go through her skull and blood would splatter all over Marsha. [She] walked around those halls like she owned the place. Because she was a nice-looking piece of . . . . You think that's gonna fly? *(shakes his head)* It's the ones like me are going to run the show! This is the only way to make you assholes finally pay attention to us. I wasn't about to settle for some rinky-dink shit. Oh, no. I blew that dumb b****'s head off and made sure a little got on James as well. But I was never going to kill him. I wanted him to live, so he could write about the day in his precious paper.

OFF STAGE VOICE OF CRIBB: Please, Herman, Stop! *(Gunshot)*

HERMAN: I shot Cribb right in the mouth. Isn't she at the hospital or something?

LAX: They had to amputate her jaw. What was left of it. She'll have to be fed intravenously.

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HERMAN: Awesome! She deserved it. Gave me a C- in phys-ed. Can you believe that? A C-! Unreal! Lax? Lax, you still with me?

LAX: *(Pause)* Why don't we take a break. I need some coffee.

CLARKSON: **(Pg 44)** *(Off-stage)* The verdict came in today on The People vs Herman Howards. Howards will be the first minor executed in the state of Iowa.

HERMAN: **(Pg 43)** Whatever . . .

LAX: *(re-inters)* **(Pg 46)** Are you ready to die, Herman?

HERMAN: When you die, it's "game over." Nothing. Blackness.

LAX: What about "reset"?

HERMAN: When you hit "reset," the game you played before doesn't have *anything* to do with the next one. All the characters come back to life.

LAX: That's not how it works in real life. Once a kid is killed, he doesn't come back.

HERMAN: *(Herman doesn't speak. His face changes. It is as if he's beginning to worry - softly)* **(Pg 47)** I dream they come back . . . I keep shooting. It's like I have unlimited bullets and they have unlimited lives. How can dead people haunt your dreams?

LAX: Why don't you ask them the next time you go to sleep?

HERMAN: Shut up! I'm fine! *(Pause)* You want to hear what else happened or not? The police came to the door and I threw a pipe bomb into the middle of the crowd. It got crazy. I was just running around shooting people left and right. It was anarchy. Awesome! *(flashback as Herman narrates)* I ran up behind Marsha and put the forty-five to her back. *(To Marsha)* Ready to die, prom queen?

MARSHA: Please don't. I'll do anything. I want to see my mom again. Pleeeeaasse!

HARMAN: Isn't it funny? She was ashamed to be caught taking to me before that. **(Pg 48)** You know what that kind of power feels like? I shot her down low. Bashed her nose with the butt of my gun and left her there to bleed. I'm glad she survived. To learn what life is like when you're not the prettiest girl in school.

LAX: (Now) You're a teacher? – What did they learn, Herman?

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HERMAN: Maybe they learned to be a little nicer to each other. [But] I doubt it. The world's gotta see more kids like me before they finally get it. That's okay, they will.

LAX: They'll finally get it?

HERMAN: No. *(he grins)* The world will see more kids like me.

LAX: *(Pause)* We have real problems in this world, Herman. Melting glaciers, massive unemployment, crumbling nations with nuclear missiles. You think I have time to worry about some depressed kid from the suburbs going into his school and killing people? Why didn't you just wait to go to college and find friends there? I mean, really!

HERMAN: It worked, didn't it? You're here, aren't you? It was the only way to get you to pay attention to me.

LAX: You're going to be killed. You destroyed hundreds of lives. You inflicted pain on innocent people. You gave up everything just to be on my show?

HERMAN: **(Pg 49)** I wasn't about to go through life being unnoticed. **(Pg 42)** Do you know what the largest generation is? Mine! Believe me, we're going to do a hell of a lot more than "Rock the Vote." This is the only way to make you assholes finally pay attention to us!

LAX: **(Pg 49)** This is not about your generation, Herman. This is about you doing unspeakable things.

HERMAN: You have to do the unspeakable if you want to be noticed.

LAX: You think anyone's going to care about you in two months? You're gonna be a footnote, listed next to a bunch of other forgotten footnotes.

HERMAN: Google me in twenty years, Lax. Then we'll see who's right. *(Pause. Herman's entire façade has melted and now we are left with a little boy)* **(Pg 50)** Between you an me? I'm scared. I don't want to die. Sometimes I wish I could take it back. You know, hit reset. But I can't. *(He cries)*

********break*********

CLARKSON: This is Chet Clarkson reporting live at the execution of Herman Howards. The highest viewed event in television history. Senator . . . your thoughts?

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SENATOR JOHN COX: America will see today that the government of the United States will not allow our children to be in danger any longer. Killing people may not stop people from killing people, but seeing the execution live sure as heck will.

CHILDREN'S AID SOCIETY REP: **(Pg 15)** Herman Howards is . . . [was] a troubled child in serious need of psychiatric treatment. What kind of message does it send to the world when America starts executing our own children on television?

SOURCE INFORMATION

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